Relative clauses and definitions

Goal: To join sentences and write clear definitions using relative pronouns, and to distinguish defining from non-defining relative clauses.

The idea in two lines: A relative clause gives information about a noun just before it. A good definition follows the pattern: term + is a / an + general class + relative clause that states its special feature.

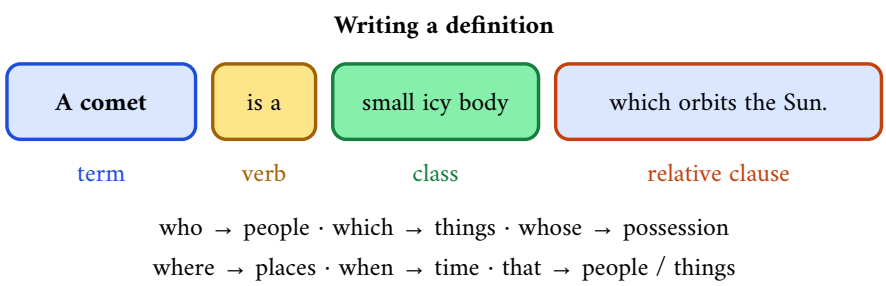


Figure 1: The four parts of a definition and the main relative pronouns.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Who** for people, **which** for things and animals, **that** for both in defining clauses.
2. **Whose** shows possession: *an astronomer whose discovery changed science.*
3. **Where** for places, **when** for time: *the year when the probe landed.*
4. **Defining clause:** essential information, no commas: *The planet which is closest to the Sun is Mercury.*
5. **Non-defining clause:** extra information, between commas, never with *that*: *Jupiter, which is a gas giant, has many moons.*
6. The relative pronoun can be omitted when it is the **object** of a defining clause: *the telescope (that) we used.*

🟢 Examples

1. Join: *Galileo was an astronomer. He improved the telescope.* **Solution:** Galileo was an astronomer **who** improved the telescope.

2. Define: *an observatory*. **Solution:** An observatory is a building **where** scientists observe the sky.
3. Join: *Saturn has rings. Its rings are made of ice and rock.* **Solution:** Saturn, **whose** rings are made of ice and rock, … / Saturn has rings **which** are made of ice and rock. **Explanation:** *its* becomes *whose*.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Repeating the pronoun: *the planet which it is red.*
- Using *that* after a comma in a non-defining clause.
- Using *which* for people or *who* for things.
- Confusing *whose* (possession) with *who's* (who is).

🟡 Quick review

- Definition = term + is a + class + relative clause.
- Who / which / that / whose / where / when.
- Defining: no commas; non-defining: commas, no *that*.
- Object pronoun can be dropped in defining clauses.

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